CS 301R · WRITING ISSUES

Bug Report Anatomy

The test: could a stranger reproduce it without asking you anything?

A person's **error** puts a **defect** in the code → when it runs, the program hits a **fault** → you see a **failure**. **A report describes the failure**; the investigation walks the chain backward.

The six parts *in the order a reader needs them*

1. **One failure per report.** Two problems, two issues: each gets fixed, closed, and found on its own.
2. **A title that summarizes the failure.**
   Weak: "Search broken" **Strong:** "Search finds nothing when the query ends with a space"
3. **Steps to reproduce,** numbered and minimal: from a known start, the fewest steps that still fail.
4. **Expected vs. actual,** as two separate lines. "It doesn't work" is neither.
5. **Environment and version:** OS, browser, the commit or release, anything non-default.
6. **Evidence:** the exact error text, a log excerpt, a screenshot. Paste text as text so it's searchable.

Not every issue is a bug. A missing feature filed in bug language needs the right type and label, not steps. A feature request gets its own discipline: the **need**, the **user**, and what they **do today instead**.

Rewrite it *the weak report, to the anatomy*

Title

Steps 1

2

3

Expected

Actual

Environment

Evidence

What we'd have to ask the reporter

Your project's bug template should ask for all six. Good reports you write from today on are CP9 portfolio material: save the links.

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